

WHAT IS A BUDGET?

A budget is actually a yearly plan divided by 12. It must account for ALL spending, including the nonmonthly items such as clothing, insurance, and maintenance, so that when those things come due, the money is already put aside to pay for them. It's a freeing feeling to know you have the money in savings to pay for the nonmonthly items that normally create such crises if you've laid nothing aside for them.

For instance, let's assume that you have a \$600 insurance payment due on your car each November. Beginning in December, you must put \$50 a month aside so that by the next November, you will have the \$600 in the bank, awaiting your insurance bill. If you don't have a budget, that \$50 per month (and any other) is usually treated like a windfall profit and spent. Then come November, it's panic and often heated arguments.

The fact that you put \$50 a month aside for insurance is a discipline, but it does NOT restrict your freedom. It frees your mind not to worry about that payment. That is the real purpose of a budget. It promotes oneness because a husband and wife can make decisions together. For instance, when you go to buy a car and have worked out a budget so that you know you have \$150 a month to spend on a car, including payments, maintenance, gasoline, and insurance, what does that mean? You KNOW you can't buy a new car. It probably means that on a \$150-a-month budget, you can't buy any car that costs more than \$75 a month per payment—and that narrows down your choices.

But this is the point where the practical (a budget) merges with the spiritual (faith). God can provide a car within your budget if you're willing to trust Him. In fact, after praying about it, you may decide that God's best is to keep the car you have and save until you can afford a better one. As you learn to be faithful in a small thing, God will entrust bigger things to you. "He who is faithful in a very little thing is faithful also in much; and he who is unrighteous in a very little thing is unrighteous also in much" (Luke 16:10).